IT & Security Policy

Meridian Freight Co. · Version 2.7 · Effective March 1, 2026 · Owner: IT Department

1. Purpose and scope

This policy explains how we protect Meridian's systems and the information our customers trust us with. It applies to all employees, contractors and temporary staff who use a Meridian account or device, whether they work in an office, in a warehouse or remotely.

Breaking this policy can expose the company to fraud, data loss and legal penalties. Serious or repeated violations may lead to disciplinary action. If you are unsure whether something is allowed, ask the IT Service Desk before you do it.

2. Getting help

Channel	Details
IT Service Desk portal	servicedesk.meridianfreight.example — for requests and non-urgent issues
Phone	Extension 4357 (HELP), Monday to Friday, 7:00 AM to 7:00 PM Eastern Time
After-hours emergencies	On-call engineer at 614-555-0199, 24/7, for outages and security incidents only

Standard requests are answered within one business day. Requests for new software are reviewed within three business days.

3. Accounts and passwords

3.1 Passwords

Passwords for Meridian accounts must be at least 14 characters long. We recommend a passphrase of four or more unrelated words. You do not need to change your password on a schedule; you must change it immediately if you think it may have been seen or stolen. Never reuse your Meridian password on any other website.

Store passwords only in the company password manager, which IT installs on every laptop. Writing passwords on paper or saving them in documents, spreadsheets or browser notes is not allowed.

3.2 Multi-factor authentication

Multi-factor authentication (MFA) is required for all Meridian accounts. Use the approved authenticator app on your phone. Text-message codes are allowed only as a temporary backup for up to 7 days, for example while you replace a lost phone. Never approve an MFA request you did not start yourself; report it to the Service Desk as a possible attack.

3.3 Shared accounts

Shared accounts are not allowed, except for the warehouse terminals, which use badge login. Never share your password or MFA codes with anyone, including your manager or IT staff. IT will never ask for your password.

4. Devices

4.1 Company devices

Company data may only be stored and processed on company-managed devices. All company laptops use full-disk encryption and lock the screen automatically after 5 minutes of inactivity. Lock your screen manually (Windows key + L) whenever you step away. Do not disable antivirus, encryption or automatic updates. Updates must be installed within 7 days of being released.

4.2 Personal phones

You may use your personal phone for email, Teams and the ShiftBoard app, but only after enrolling it in the company's mobile device management (MDM) app. MDM lets IT erase company data from the phone if it is lost or when you leave Meridian; it cannot see your personal photos, messages or browsing history. Personal laptops and tablets may not be used to access company systems, except the Payroll portal.

4.3 Working remotely and traveling

Use the company VPN whenever you access internal systems such as ShiftBoard, the finance system or file shares from outside a Meridian office. The VPN is always required on public Wi-Fi, such as in hotels, airports and cafés. At home, the VPN is required for internal systems but not for email, Teams or other cloud applications.

If you plan to work from another country, inform the IT Service Desk at least 5 working days before you travel, after your request has been approved by People & Culture. Some countries block our VPN or restrict encryption software; in these countries IT may provide a temporary loan laptop. Company devices may not be taken to countries on the restricted list published on the IT intranet page.

4.4 Lost or stolen devices

Report a lost or stolen laptop or phone to the IT Service Desk immediately, and no later than 24 hours after you notice it is missing. Outside business hours, call the on-call engineer. IT will lock the device and erase company data remotely. Also report thefts to the police and send the report number to the Service Desk.

5. Software and AI tools

5.1 Installing software

Install software only from the Software Center on your laptop. If the software you need is not available, request it through the Service Desk portal. IT checks each new request for security and licensing, and replies within three business days. Browser extensions follow the same rule: only extensions listed in the Software Center may be installed.

5.2 Using AI tools

Meridian provides an approved AI assistant for writing, summarizing and analysis, available from the Software Center. You may use it with Public and Internal information. Confidential and Restricted information must never be entered into any AI tool other than the approved assistant, and Restricted information must never be entered into any AI tool at all. Always check AI-generated content before you share it: you remain responsible for its accuracy.

6. Classifying and handling information

All information at Meridian falls into one of four classes. Label documents with their class when they are Confidential or Restricted.

Class	Examples	Rules
Public	Website content, press releases, published price lists	No restrictions
Internal	Intranet pages, team plans, this policy	Share only with employees and contractors
Confidential	Customer lists, shipment data, financial reports, negotiated rates	Share only with people who need it for their work; never on USB drives
Restricted	Customer contracts, payroll, employee health and personal data, bank details	Access approved by the data owner; encrypted when sent outside Meridian; never on USB drives or personal devices

USB drives and other removable storage are blocked on company laptops by default. If you need to exchange large files with a customer, use the secure file transfer service instead. Paper documents with Confidential or Restricted information must be stored in locked cabinets and destroyed in the shredding bins, not in regular recycling.

7. Email and phishing

Most attacks start with an email. Be careful with messages that create urgency, ask you to change bank details, or ask for passwords or gift cards. Emails from outside Meridian are marked with an orange

"External" banner.

If you receive a suspicious email, do not click links or open attachments. Use the "Report phishing" button in Outlook, which sends the message to the security team and removes it from your inbox. If you already clicked a link or entered your password, call the Service Desk right away; quick action makes a big difference. You will not be blamed for reporting a mistake.

Any request to change a customer's or supplier's bank details must be confirmed by phone, using a number already on file, before the change is made. Never use the phone number written in the email itself.

8. Reporting security incidents

A security incident is any event that could harm the confidentiality, integrity or availability of our information: a lost device, a suspicious login, malware, data sent to the wrong person, or an unknown person in a restricted area. Report every incident to the Service Desk as soon as possible, and within 1 hour if it involves Restricted information. Do not try to investigate on your own, and do not delete any evidence.

The security team classifies incidents by severity and keeps you informed. If personal data was exposed, the Legal team decides whether customers, employees or authorities must be notified.

9. Backups and retention

Files saved on the company file shares and in the cloud storage are backed up every day, and backups are kept for 35 days. Files saved only on your laptop's desktop are not backed up. Emails are kept for 3 years and then deleted automatically, unless the Legal team has placed them on hold.

10. Physical security and guests

Wear your badge visibly in all Meridian buildings. Do not let people follow you through a badge-controlled door. Visitors must sign in at reception, wear a visitor badge and be accompanied at all times in warehouses and server rooms.

Guests can use the "Meridian-Guest" Wi-Fi network. The guest password changes on the first day of each month and is available at reception. The guest network has no access to internal systems. Employees should not connect company laptops to the guest network.

11. When you leave Meridian

Your accounts are disabled at the end of your last working day. Before you leave, move any work files you created to the team file share, and remove personal files from your laptop. On your last day, return your laptop and badge to your manager or to the IT Service Desk, and remove the MDM app from your personal phone, which erases company data from it.